

"I REALLY WANT TO BE RECOGNISED AS A TALENTED actor. I don't want to play just one type of role. I want to experiment and make it big."

PRACHI DESAI, Actor, 20

Pillar of Strength

In everything she does, Desai has the rock-solid support of her mother, who has been accompanying her through her crazy 34-hour schedules.



In reality, she's yet not over her penchant for stuffed toys, but on screen, Prachi Desai has effortlessly essayed the role of a mother and wife. In 2006, when her friends were struggling with board preparations, Desai was busy memorising two-page dialogues that Bani would mouth on her debut show *Kasamh Se* on Zee TV. Landing the protagonist's role with Balaji Telefilms has its advantages, but not when you arrive with no prior experience. Belonging to a simple Gujarati household from Surat, she had nothing but talent and grit to her advantage. "The first few months were traumatic. On a few occasions, I even told my mother I wanted to quit and go back to studying," says Desai. But what keeps her going is the realisation that she is living her dream—a feat few can manage at the age of 17. Through *Kasamh Se*, she became a household name and later bagged an offer from the dance reality show *Jhalak Dikha Jaa*, which she went on to win in 2007.

That's when she also gave a look test for Abhishek Kapoor's *Rock On!!* But taking on the project meant giving up *Kasamh Se*. "I owed my success to the show. But *Kasamh Se* was all set for a time leap. I didn't think I could do justice to the role," she says. With her film debut in *Rock On!!* (2008), Desai, who is currently living in a Balaji guest house, has established herself as an accomplished actor. She might be the poised artiste, speaking with dignity about her life and forthcoming projects, but scratch the top layer just a little and there's the giggling 20-year-old on the threshold of stardom, who may miss frolicking with her girlfriends, but won't trade her success for anything. A graduation degree in psychology may come through if her parents manage to prevail upon her, but right now, the only writing that makes Desai happy is her signed autographs.

by Swati Mathur